



**“People won’t look at Zak for his statistics—they will look at him for impact, spells that win matches.”**

**VVS LAXMAN**

It is the fast bowler’s friend and enemy, capable of repeatedly torquing itself into biomechanical punishment and equally capable of succumbing to stress and collapse.

Until recently, such physical unpredictability was Zaheer’s calling card, from his high-decibel debut in 2000 all the way to England 2007. When after an indifferent first day in Lord’s, he took 18 wickets and set up India’s historic series win.

Before that he had limped out of landmark series in Pakistan and Australia (twice). He says, “I would do everything right, do the fitness, the rehab. I would return, nets would be fine but then some other part would break down in a match.”

On at least one occasion, body and spirit broken, he found himself in the dressing room in frustrated, helpless tears. “I felt I was letting the team down, as if I was a burden on them,” he says. Lacking neither in courage nor rage, he has bowled with a snapped quadricep in Sri Lanka and a torn ligament in Australia. He has shortened his run, cut down on his leap during his delivery stride, and has used his recent injury lay-offs to work on core-strength—and not, it seems, only in the physiological sense.

“He has a very strong self-belief,

an inner drive to do well,” says spinner Murali Kartik. For a player often called ‘lazy’, Zaheer’s response to every setback has been marked by a ferocious appetite for redemption.

In Pakistan 2006, former coach Greg Chappell had privately declared Zaheer ‘finished’, words that reached him. Dropped from the subsequent tour of the West Indies, Zaheer hard-sold himself to Worcestershire. Its captain Vikram Solanki says county cricket, “asked Zak all the questions he needed to answer”. About how badly he wanted his place back, how much he cared about being India’s frontline bowler. Away from Indian cricket’s fractious atmosphere of the time, he bowled more than 600 overs in long spells for his 78 wickets, perfecting his art, understanding his options and what to do when.

The county game, says VVS Laxman, “transformed” Zaheer. “He had always looked to bowl quick and take wickets. But county cricket taught him to bowl within himself, when to attack and when to contain.” It is an art that the fast bowler understands as he gets older. When he finds that groove, he goes from struggling apprentice to master, a stage many believe Zaheer is

entering now. His best is yet to be.

Caught up in the tides of his career, there is a lot that we forget about him. That Zaheer is from Shrirampur, a town not easily found on maps. That he bowled with a leather ball only at the age of 17, encountered weight training only at 20. That he is smart enough to get into an instrumentation engineering course and was mocked by his college principal for dreaming about a cricket ticket. That this cool world traveller was once a boy easily felled by the dessert table at a buffet. Today, he remembers that kid by rewarding himself with something sweet after a good day at the office.

Yuvraj Singh says, “Zak was always passionate about cricket, always angry, now he’s much more mellow.” Yet he is still bursting with so many masterplans, strategies and opinions, that Yuvraj has nicknamed him “*Zaheerbhai Ideawalle*”.

Srinath thinks he had the calibre to have picked up 350 wickets, but Laxman says, “People won’t look at him for statistics, they will look at Zaheer for impact.” The man insists that all he seeks is rhythm and not the 200 wicket mark. “Why limit myself to numbers? I just enjoy bowling. As long as I’m swinging the ball, and I’m in good rhythm, the wickets will come.”

But what is this thing bowlers call rhythm? With all the patience of a man trying to teach trigonometry to a 10-year-old, Zaheer explains, “It is a feeling that everything is in control. You size up a batsman and decide that you can get him if you bowl in a particular area, and then that’s exactly what you are able to do. Your body and mind are in sync, you are on autopilot, there’s no stress on your body, you don’t feel tired, everything is smooth.”

Smooth for him, of course, but very rough for anyone 22 yards away. ■